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UNIV 102

Final Essay

12. 15. 23.

Over the course of this semester, I've been challenged to think in ways I'd never imagined. In every class, I learned something new, shared multiple laughs with classmates, and simply enjoyed being there. This class was different than most, and I think that's what made it so special to me. Everything from the group discussions to the talks from highly accomplished individuals, this class brought a new spark to every Monday of mine. One of the things that interested me most about the class was hearing the other people in my group's opinions on questions that would arise from our group leader. Often times, we would respectfully disagree on topics, which I thought was a healthy way of learning.

I enjoyed one of the first journal entries where we had to write a letter to a family member about climate change. It made me think that we don't really speak about it that much at home and maybe we should. It made me think also of another topic as to whether doctors should be partly at fault for climate change. This topic became more personal as my family is made up basically of all doctors. From pediatricians to anesthesiologists to dermatologists, it runs in the family. Personally, I do not agree with the statement that it's on the doctors as I believe that everyone in every field should educate others on topics like climate change and not specifically doctors because they are in the science field. Similar to other professions, doctors' actions—such as the amount of energy they use in hospitals, the amount of garbage they produce, or their own carbon footprint—have an effect on the environment. But human activity as a whole, encompassing a range of domains such as industry, transportation, agriculture, energy generation, and personal lifestyles, bears the primary blame for climate change. Healthcare systems' main goals are to treat patients and promote public health, even though their resource and energy

usage has an influence on carbon emissions and the environment. In actuality, medical experts frequently have a significant impact on the public's understanding of the negative effects of climate change on health and on advocacy for climate action. By implementing sustainable practices within healthcare facilities, supporting public health campaigns on health risks related to climate change, advocating for policies that lessen the environmental impact of healthcare, and funding research on the relationship between climate change and health, healthcare organizations and professionals can make a positive contribution to efforts to mitigate and adapt to climate change.

Furthermore, I'd definitely say that my thoughts about climate change have changed, but in a sense that I just know more now. Also, because I know more, I think that this has made me more anxious about the future. Oftentimes in our group, we would ask if thought about our lives in 50+ years and how life could be different then, and most of us don't really think that far, but after a while and pondering after class, it scared me a bit how the world could completely change and our ways of life and daily activities might be hindered because we did not take enough action today. With temperatures around the world rising, there are significant implications of climate change for weather patterns. Worldwide lives, infrastructure, and economies are at risk due to extreme weather events such as heatwaves, droughts, heavy rainfall, and increasingly frequent and destructive hurricanes. Rising sea levels could cause catastrophic floods, erosion, and the forced relocation of millions of people from coastal areas. These effects would also have a significant effect on ecosystems, agriculture, and human settlements. Existential threats to biodiversity arise from species' struggles to adapt to changing environments, climate swings, and shifting food supplies. The ensuing changes in the environment may cause unbalances in food chains, which would have much more devastating effects on people. There are so many things that could trigger others like a domino effect and we are not even realizing it today.

This class has also helped me battle these problems with climate change outside of the

classroom in the years to come and beyond. First and foremost, lowering one's carbon footprint is mostly dependent on one's own behavior. Adopting sustainable behaviors like recycling and composting, cutting back on energy use, and choosing renewable energy sources are just a few examples of how one can dramatically reduce their personal emissions of greenhouse gases. Also, participating in the community is another effective strategy. In addition to bringing communities together, volunteering for neighborhood environmental organizations, taking part in beach clean-ups, planting trees, and supporting urban gardening programs also contributes to the preservation of ecosystems and biodiversity while building resilience against the effects of climate change. Campaigning and raising awareness are also effective means of enacting change. People can also use social media, neighborhood forums, or local gatherings to spread the word about climate issues, encourage discussion, and rally support for climate action. Widespread participation can be sparked by promoting thoughtful debates and informing people about the need to address climate change immediately. Customer decisions can have a big impact. Choosing environmentally friendly items, cutting back on single-use plastics, and endorsing eco-friendly enterprises encourage market forces that push the industry toward sustainability and greener business practices. These are all just ideas, and obviously it is hard to accomplish them all, but simply having knowledge of them and how to help is the first step.

Classes like this should be instilled in middle school and high schools so that the up and coming generations gain knowledge earlier as the problem continues to rise. I feel like, although I'm grateful for this class and all that I gained from it, I wish that I had learned it earlier in my career so that I could deepen my understanding and take action sooner. Plus, I believe this would make a better overall impact across the world with kids being raised with awareness. I love to reflect on classes like this at the end of the semester because it makes you realize that all the time and effort were worth it. At times, I did not feel like going to the conversations, making my gallery walk poster, or attending the play, but in the end, I always learned something new

because the class was engaging, interacting, and fun.

In conclusion, I have learned a lot this semester and challenged my thoughts in climate change while engaging with fellow classmates. I became more anxious about the future of the earth, and it made me want to take action sooner so that my life and my kids lives can be the best possible. I always find it hard to think about something so big and how a person so small in the planet like myself can actually make an impact. It seems unrealistic, but what if everyone else is thinking the same thing? That's what makes it more visible to me, because everyone together makes a change, not just one person. I'd recommend this class to many students, interested in the topic or not, because it teaches you so much more than climate change. It teaches you interaction with classmates, talking skills, agreeing and disagreeing, listening closely, creativity, staying curious, and pondering the future.